The belongs_to association supports these options:

- :autosave
- :class_name
- :counter_cache
- :dependent
- :foreign_key
- :inverse_of
- :polymorphic
- :touch
- :validate
- :optional

#### 4.1.2.1 :autosave

If you set the :autosave option to true, Rails will save any loaded members and destroy members that are marked for destruction whenever you save the parent object.

#### 4.1.2.2 :class_name

If the name of the other model cannot be derived from the association name, you can use the :class_name option to supply the model name. For example, if an order belongs to a customer, but the actual name of the model containing customers is Patron, you'd set things up this way:

```
class Order < ActiveRecord::Base
  belongs_to :customer, class_name: "Patron"
end
```

#### 4.1.2.3 :counter_cache

The :counter_cache option can be used to make finding the number of belonging objects more efficient. Consider these models:

```
class Order < ActiveRecord::Base
  belongs_to :customer
end
class Customer < ActiveRecord::Base
  has_many :orders
end
```

With these declarations, asking for the value of @customer.orders.size requires making a call to the database to perform a COUNT(*) query. To avoid this call, you can add a counter cache to the*belonging* model:

```
class Order < ActiveRecord::Base
  belongs_to :customer, counter_cache: true
end
class Customer < ActiveRecord::Base
  has_many :orders
end
```

With this declaration, Rails will keep the cache value up to date, and then return that value in response to the size method.

Although the :counter_cache option is specified on the model that includes the belongs_todeclaration, the actual column must be added to the *associated* model. In the case above, you would need to add a column named orders_count to the Customer model. You can override the default column name if you need to:

```
class Order < ActiveRecord::Base
  belongs_to :customer, counter_cache: :count_of_orders
end
class Customer < ActiveRecord::Base
  has_many :orders, counter_cache: :count_of_orders
end
```

You only need to specify the :counter_cache option on the "has_many side" of the association when using a custom name for the counter cache.